

Here he was, a boy, not quite 6 or 7. Somewhere in the middle. He boarded the plane with his mother, a lady he had only met twice before. The lady was somewhere the age of 26. In the lady's hands was the boy's sister, one of two. She had just turned 1.

The boy and his mother took their seats, and the sister remained in the lady's arms. The flight attendant walked over to the boy and said something. It was gibberish and the boy understood nothing. His mother nodded and smiled politely. The flight attendant reached down the side of the boy's left leg and pulled out a device. The boy immediately recognized what it was and lost himself to it.

Time passed and the mother and her daughter fell asleep. The boy did not. The cabin of the airplane had its lights dimmed, and he could see his own reflection on the surface of the device. His reflection told him

he was sad. He was sad to leave his grandparents. They had taken care of him for the better of 6 or 7 years. No, there was no reason to be sad; he knew he would be back in their care. His mother had told him he was just going to some country to pick up an iPad and will come right back and return him to the grandparents.

He was wrong. The boy will not see his grandparents on home soil for at least another 10 years. Nor will he breathe the same air from the land that he was born in. The friends he had made in kindergarten will come by his grandparents' apartment, asking where he was, and leave with the same answer day after day.

Looking back at the boy's life, I do not know what the right decision was. However, I know for certain that if the same boy knew what awaited him for the next 6 years, he

would have fought tooth and nail to be left with his grandparents.

As he touched down in some strange new country, his father, a man he had never seen before, greeted him. The father put his arm around the boy, who burst into tears. He wanted his grandparents, but circumstances will prevent it for the foreseeable future. The father was happy, for he had finally held his son for the first time ever.

The family drove home, and the mother went straight to making dinner. Some sort of soup noodles were on the menu. The father gave the comfiest chair in the house for the boy to sit on. The boy himself had recovered from missing his grandparents, and wandered around the house, curious to this new environment he was in. The family had a housekeeper, and she was hanging up the laundry. She gave a kind smile to the boy and

said something to him. The boy never understood what she said and never replied in any way.

After dinner, the housekeeper left, and it was time for bed. The boy slept in his own bed, whilst his sister, mother, and father slept in another. When he woke up, his father was gone. Off to work. The mother and the boy's sister were with him. The boy was quite proud of himself, for he did not cry through the night, as he was known to do so when spending the night somewhere that was not his grandparents' apartment.

The three ate breakfast, and the mother took the boy and his sister out to go sightseeing. The boy did not care. He did not understand what was so interesting that he saw. Rivers, beaches, parks, he had seen them all before. The only thing that piqued his interest was the food. He would soon later

learn that one of his favourite foods in this new country was called a “Potato Top Pie”.

Days passed, and the boy started getting used to the new country. He still could not understand a single thing people would say to him though. Additionally, the boy was starting primary school in a few weeks. He had to learn a new language, or else he would not be able to get anywhere in his new school.

And so, it began. To make sure his son knew some words in English and how to introduce himself, the father devised a demanding, if not cruel, regime. The boy was subjected to repeating the same word in a list verbally 10 times. The list contained 200 basic English words, such as “Hello”, “Hi”, “Good”, “Morning”, “Thanks”, and so on. He would do this before and after breakfast. Each word eventually became so ingrained in the boy’s

mind, tongue, and throat, that he would unconsciously tense up each time he spoke it, even 3 years later when he was a fluent speaker of the language.

After lunch, the boy was demanded by his father to write the list of words out, 5 times. Each word had to be written with precision, not scribbles. If the father did not like the boy's handwriting, he would demand the boy to re-write the word.

It was only after dinner that the boy had a break. This schedule was repeated for two weeks. If the boy complained or started crying out of frustration, the father hit him. The man physically abused his own son and forced him to keep going with the demanding schedule.

The mother supported the father fully. Even when her own son had blood pouring out of his nose like a faucet, or the right side

of his face was swollen like a balloon, the mother did not step in to stop the father. She even contributed to the abuse, more with her tongue than her hands. With each slap, punch, kick, scold, the boy's heart greyed with coldness, and emotions died within. The boy rarely laughed or smiled in his household, and the abuse throughout his life almost destroyed his ability to cry, to relieve sadness through tears. He became scared and mad of the figures that he was meant to love, meant to look up to. But no, this life was not going to be an easy one for him.

The housekeeper – I wish I could say stepped in and stopped the madness – turned a blind eye to such abuse. In the future, when the physical abuse lessened significantly to a point where it almost became 0, the boy would wonder what made the housekeeper comfortable around such

violence. The boy was wrong. The housekeeper was never comfortable around such violence, which was the reason why she always took her heart medications before coming to work.

All adults were once disobedient children, and that fact was proven when the boy started at his primary school. He was given a book to take home to read out loud with his parents, and he struggled greatly. Several words in the book were not in the list that his father gave him. The boy's father would say out loud one word and the boy successfully repeated it after him. However, the two would go over the entire book, and the boy could not memorize the pronunciation of upwards of 100 words in one sitting.

Of course, the father became frustrated. Of course, the only way he could resolve such frustration was to use physical abuse. Which



he did. Books became weapons to the boy. The covers of books would become deeply intimate with the face of the boy, as they were repeatedly smacked across them.

To make sure the boy never retreated into his own world when he took the beating, the man would scream and shout questions at the boy and make him answer. The boy could not escape the violence even through his mind. The man had to make sure the boy knew pain, and the boy did. Each time the boy's nose got hit throughout his life, he would always be taken back to the times where the man struck him at the exact same space, which always produced a river of blood.

The housekeeper tried helping the boy out by teaching him the words – perhaps the only time she tried intervening – but the father was watching, and he even grew frustrated

just at the sight of his boy not being able to memorize all the words.

Blood from the boy's nose would stain the pages of the book, and the schoolteachers would become concerned for the boy's home life. The boy told them in broken English what happened at home (he thought there was nothing wrong with it) and the school's principal went to the boy's house to have a talk with the parents. I do not know what words were exchanged between them. This was the first time the boy told someone how his home life was.

It should come to no surprise that the boy's parents disobeyed the principal. Day after day, the same event would happen once the boy returned from school. Home, a place where every child takes solace in, became the complete opposite for the boy.

Due to the adults at home having a

disappointing ability in teaching, the school took note of the lack of progress of speaking in the boy and assigned a specialized teacher to teach him English. That teacher was the school's librarian, Narnia.

The boy and Narnia will form a tight bond, something that will last all the way to the boy's adulthood, and beyond. In contrast to the style of teaching at home, Narnia's was soft and patient, and the boy loved it. He learned more in one session with Narnia than he had with the adults at home for two weeks. Narnia also introduced one of the boy's favourite picture books: Mechanical Harry. This book would ignite a fire in the boy, a fire that burned deeply for problem solving and using it to ease burdens of everyday life. Narnia showed to the boy that books were not to be used as weapons, but as sources that are rich in knowledge, fuel for creativity,

and the worlds that were created from a person's imagination.

In Narnia's care, the boy's brain began to blossom in terms of creativity and imagination. The boy spent all his free time in the library, either being taught by Narnia in English, or reading books that grabbed his attention.

At home, books were sources of pain and suffering, but in the school's library, books were keys to worlds where the boy could get himself lost in; to escape and forget what was waiting at home, even if it was just for a moment.

Fortunately, the father and the mother would eventually stop using books as their main source of pain to the boy. Unfortunately, that does not mean the abuse stopped. Even when the boy started to get the hang of the

English language, the parents would move onto something else to torment the boy with.

Next up was mathematics.

Through Narnia's care and the parents' abuse, the boy's brain had been completely rewired, with its neuroplasticity being significantly increased. (I wonder if this would have been possible if these events took place later in the boy's life). The boy's brain was now a learning machine and could grasp new stimuli much exceptionally faster than your average 7-year-old.

Thus, the boy learned all the ways of addition and subtraction without much effort. Numbers started becoming more appealing to the boy. It was as if they danced exactly how the boy wanted, did exactly what he wanted, and the outcome was always the same. The boy loved it. However, a high capacity for learning did not mean the boy's

brain could go through processes faster. So, the boy struggled with multiplication and division.

To help him, the father printed out a multiplication chart and had his son memorise it. When the boy thought he was ready, the father would say two numbers, and if the boy could not calculate the product of the two fast enough, the boy was sent back to memorising the chart.

Mathematics will eventually be a big part of the boy's life. He hated it but was quite good at it. Throughout the boy's early childhood – from 7 to 9 – the father would occasionally give out 150 tedious calculations for the boy to do by hand. This had negative and positive impacts, which will become apparent later in the boy's high school life.

While the boy's maths skills were above an average for his age, his English skills were still

much much below. The father and mother both did not like the boy's handwriting, and so they devised a regime to improve it. Whenever the boy had free time, the parents would make him handwrite text from magazines, books, newspapers, or whatever books that were available. If the parents did not like the appearance of words that the boy wrote, he was given a smack and had to start all over again. He had to write through tears and blisters that formed on the inside of his finger.

Soon, the teachers at school noticed the boy's improved handwriting, and started complimenting the boy. Some would go as far as telling the parents that they had done a good job, not knowing what the boy had to go through. This gave the green light to the parents to continue their vile ways, as it was for the boy's "own good".

With Narnia helping the boy with his English skills, and the parents at home exercising the boy's analytical mind, it soon became apparent that the usual schoolwork of a Year 2 student was much too easy for the boy. Thus, the choice was made between the principal and the parents to have the boy skip Year 3. This was great news for both the parents and the boy. For the parents, their way of "teaching" and "discipline" had been proven, with the boy skipping a year being solid evidence. It is strange to me that even though the parents' thought their way of pedagogy was so successful, they would not repeat it onto their remaining children – at least not on the same scale as it was with their son. For the boy, skipping Year 3 to Year

4 was a pivotal decision that will shape the rest of his life.



2017 was the final year of primary teaching for Josh. It was also the year he met the boy. On the first day of teaching the boy, Josh knew he was in for a ride. The kid sitting before him would almost pick up anything Josh could throw at him, whether it was new maths concepts, the spelling of new words, the pronunciation of complex words, and even non-academic stimuli such as the steps to folding origami, the boy would consume it all. The boy surprised Josh with his voracity to learn and his capacity for retention.

Josh knew that he would only ever keep up with the boy for so long. So, he introduced the boy to something that will entertain him for a long time: programming. First, he taught the boy how to use a computer, and

then taught him the concept of programming. It was the perfect stimulus for him, and he got immediately hooked on it,

and would spend the rest of the school year rushing through the classwork to disappear off underneath a table to program and code something. The computer would do exactly what the boy programmed it to do, and it was amazing. The boy was in control of everything.

Josh also worked closely with Narnia, to ensure that whatever schoolwork he gave to the boy matched the boy's current English skill.

Mostly, the boy created video games when he coded, due to the almost non-existent screen time he had at home. However, when it came to complex games, the boy did not have the knowledge nor mathematical ability to create such games. To help him, Josh advanced the boy even further than his peers.

Algebra, graphs, and the basics of trigonometry were taught to the boy, who consumed all of it.

Josh and Narnia became the type of mother and father that the boy desperately needed. School became a place of peace and kindness, a place that contrasted deeply with the boy's home. The school and the home were a perfect ying and yang.

There was one big weakness with the boy's academic capability, and Josh knew that the boy would eventually come face to face with it. Every time Josh taught the boy something, it almost always seemed like the boy was just memorizing what he was saying and not actually understanding it. Josh knew that this weakness of the boy would eventually consume him, and Josh was right. The boy thrived in analytical calculations but immensely struggled with word problems

and multi-step questions. It was as if the road to the solution was not straight, the boy would not be able to navigate himself to it. The boy also realised it himself as well. Each time he got a problem wrong, he always expected Josh to come over and scream or slap his face. But no, Josh did not resort to violence. He attempted to help the boy with his weakness by teaching him problem solving skills, and not to always rely on rote learning. Josh told the boy that a self that is curated for ease and comfort is a beautifully furnished room with no purpose, and confronting weakness is to build a door that leads to further development on the outside.

Sadly, Josh had very little idea what the boy's home life was like at the time. Wanting the boy to improve his problem-solving skills even further, he dropped off five booklets of problem-solving activities at the boy's house

for him to do over the school holidays. The boy would learn that any academic activity that falls into his parents' hands has the potential to turn his life into suffering. The parents thanked Josh for having such care in their son, but this polite demeanour was immediately removed when the teacher left. The boy was sent straight to work. He was made to do all the booklets by the time the school holidays were up. The father threatened the boy that if he made a single mistake, there would be hell to pay.

I know of the boy's current problem-solving abilities. I am certain that if the boy did not do those booklets with intense fear at the back of his head, he would have improved his problem-solving abilities much further than he would have hoped. Of course, we know that is not the case. And so, in the future when the time called for exceptional

problem-solving abilities, the boy would always fall short. It was also always by the smallest of margins that he did so.

To say that Josh and Narnia had no clue what was happening in the boy's home would be a fib. Both have worked extensively with the boy, and both never heard him mention anything related to home. Narnia would never hear anything about the boy's mother, how she was, what food she would cook, and Josh would never hear anything about the boy's father, what job he worked, and what trips he brought the boy on. The only sliver of insight they had was when Josh handed back one of the boy's problem-solving worksheets that scored 0, and the boy practically started hyperventilating. The boy did not need to say anything out loud, as his actions implied everything.

At this point in the boy's life, the housekeeper had left, and his kid sister had also flown into the country with his grandparents. It was the boy's first time seeing his grandparents for the first time in 3 years, but it was disturbing he never really missed them at all. He did not remember any of the affection the grandparents had shown him when he was younger; they had just become two other people in the boy's life.

If the grandparents were shocked by the boy's coldness, they hid it well. But soon they would see why. The abuse the parents of the boy laid on him were not exempt in the presence of the grandparents, who did not try anything to stop it, as they themselves also practiced similar ways of discipline on their kids too. But it did disturb the grandparents to watch their son almost *enjoying* hurting someone else.

Even the sister that had just flown in was not able to escape the abuse. She had a penchant to eat very slowly, and no matter what, the parents could not find a way to make her eat faster. They grew frustrated, and no words were needed to be said for what they did next. She also was meant to start school soon and still had to learn English.

Luckily, the youngest sister almost never experienced such pain, partly because she was the mother's favourite. Sadly, as the family grew more dysfunctional with each passing year, this would change horribly later in her life.

Family politics grew worse as the grandparents were temporarily living with the family of five. The mother knew that the grandfather did not approve of her, and fights between her and the father happened in almost regular intervals of time. The parents



did not care who they fought in front of. The boy would hear everything, and when the parents argued about the boy, he would hear what they truly thought of him. It depressed him greatly, and from this, a hatred of his home and all of its inhabitants grew.

With the boy growing older, bigger, and stronger, it soon became obvious that he had inherited his father's athletic genes. He was stronger and faster than most of his peers, even the older ones. A sports teacher at the boy's primary school took note of this and encouraged the boy to do as many sports as possible. Thus, in Year 5, the boy participated in football, cricket, volleyball, touch rugby, softball, futsal, and athletics. The boy found he was exceptionally good at football, futsal, and touch rugby, thanks to his natural speed. In athletics, every event that did not involve running the boy failed miserably. Even in

events such as long jump where the boy knew he could do well in, he somehow just never succeeded. One of his classmates chalked it up to the boy's lack of confidence.

For the boy's parents, especially his father, these sports were just another thing they could belittle the boy for. Whenever the boy did not do well, the boy's father would lecture the boy for hours as to what he did wrong, even in sports the boy's father never played, such as football and futsal. To add to the suffering, the father made the boy do 70 push-ups and run 2 kilometres every morning before breakfast. This regime was eventually dismantled by the boy's grandfather, who saw this as inhumane for a kid who was 9.

Before it was dismantled, the fitness and strength of the boy grew immensely, which directly contributed to his success in sports. The boy won a football competition with his

team, came third in 100m sprinting in the city, fourth in 400m, and first in 1500m. The boy got a lot of attention, and people enquired about his training. This would lead those people to praise the boy's father, who would always put on a charismatic facade in front of others. The boy at his current age was self-conscious enough to become enraged with his parents for everything they have done. But with no way to reciprocate such suffering to the people who caused it, he could only take it out on others.

So, with Josh leaving the primary school at the end of the previous year, and Narnia spending almost no time with the boy anymore, the boy spiralled out of control. He became close with others who were only at school to waste time. They became delinquents. They would disrupt class, bully others, and even go as far as threatening a

teacher. The boy started getting into fights with delinquents from other schools, and he won all of them except the ones where the number difference was too big. He loved the sensation of winning fights, as he knew he was in control the entire time. However, he grew prideful of his strength, which only made the abuse worse.

The school would eventually have enough of the bullying that was occurring and would expel two of the boy's friends from school. The boy himself was lucky. The new principal (the old one had left to become a principal at an intermediate school) knew a fair bit of what occurred in the boy's home. He was exempt from expulsion. The principal told him that he had great potential, and it was a shame he got himself involved with the likes of the other boys.

Whether the words of the principal had any effect on the boy, I do not know. What I do know is that from then onwards, the boy became increasingly lonely. Due to a record of bullying, other children steered away from him. The boy would often be found by himself in the library, lost in a good book. He barely ever programmed or stimulated his brain with textbook problems again.

It is important for me to say that at this point in the boy's life, the physical abuse at home had started to decrease. In between the abuse, the family of five actually functioned. The grandparents had left, and so the fights between the mother and the father had lessened (although it still did occur at almost regular intervals), and the boy could have proper conversations with his parents without the fear of being punched or kicked. Of course, it wasn't a perfect world, and the

mother's verbal abuse was still rampant. The lessening of the physical abuse makes me wonder, *is it good or bad?* Yes, the abuse happens less now, but does that not make the moments where the abuse *does happen* worse? The boy may feel like he is actually part of the family now, but would it not feel like immense betrayal the next time he was abused? The question effectively became this: is it better for a prisoner to be constantly tortured, or is it better to let them experience joy before subjecting them to more torture? I knew the boy also frequently asked himself that question too. His mind was in such an internal state of conflict, the parents unknowingly caused a third type of abuse: psychological.

The boy also did notice the decrease in physical abuse, and so it came as a shock to

him when the father dished out the worst beating the boy will ever take in his life.

It started with the boy walking home from school. The father was outside on the porch scrolling on his phone. A fellow classmate walked past the boy and greeted him. The boy greeted him back by nodding his head. The father did not see this as a proper reply, and so he told the boy to write out the entire contents of a dictionary. If the boy had not kept said dictionary at school where he thought it would be more useful, the afternoon might have turned out to be different.

There had to be a reason for the father's rage after the boy told him this. Unfortunately, I do not know what that reason was and the boy is in the same boat as me. The father hurled a wooden chair at the boy, which struck him on the back of his

head. Three deep gashes started to gush blood. When the boy turned to try and run, he was faced with a wall that was stained with his own blood. Now all he could do was scream and cry in pain as the man grabbed the boy's arm and twisted him around and stabbed him in the lower back with a piece of wood that splintered off the chair. It was chaos, it was pain, it was bloody, it was as if all the years of suffering had manifested itself into a being just to deliver this beating to the boy.

Somehow, he managed to escape. The rest of the day was poorly remembered by the boy, for he suffered short-term memory loss due to the trauma on his head. I do know that the boy eventually came back to the house, his hair matted with dry blood. That is all I know. I wish I knew more, as this was another pivotal moment in the boy's life, where he



realised what the man is truly capable of. Interestingly, the boy felt no fear when he saw the man again. He would no longer feel any emotions toward that man again. Even years later, when the man cracked a joke, the boy would laugh, but it was a laugh not out of joy, but of reflex upon hearing a joke. The boy would also later realise that he had come face to face with death, and was lucky death had no interest in him at the time. The boy and the man would never speak of that afternoon ever again; there was no need, it was all ingrained in each of their memories.

One teacher at school eventually noticed the scars on the back of the boy's head. His classmates did too. On a random day, the boy was called to the school hall, and to his surprise Josh was there, and no one else. Josh told the boy that he had suspected things were not okay for the boy back at home, but

he never had proof. But now he did. Josh asked the boy where the three scars on the back of his head came from. The boy, for whatever reason, did not tell Josh the truth. He told him it came from a skateboarding accident. He insisted that was the cause of the gashes on the back of his head.

Josh could only take the boy's word, as he still only had suspicion, and not evidence. As he watched the boy leave the hall, his body was overcome with sadness. The boy had not yet realised that there are people willing to help. Josh sat by himself in the hall for hours, debating whether it was the right choice to call child protection services. In the end, he did not contact them, and he drove away from the school with tears in his eyes.

I must say with full honesty, that I cried myself to sleep for several days due to Josh and the boy's conversation. Why, boy? Why

did you not tell him the truth? WHY? Just when the first glimpses of light shines into your dark world, why must you turn and retreat back into the shadows? Did you find comfort in the familiar dark, rather than in the glare of the unfamiliar light?

These questions forever remained unanswered, despite the numerous number of hours I have spent pondering them.

Child protection services did come anyway. The two ladies requested to interview the boy, who had Narnia along as company. One of the ladies asked the boy about his home life, which if the boy thought the question was not about the abuse, he would answer. Before the ladies left, they asked one final question to the boy: what is your favourite part about your home?

The boy tried hard to think of an answer, but could not come up with one. In the end,

the lady got silence for an answer, but the silence was what she was looking for.

Months after the incident, the boy would be called to the principal's second time in his life. The man was already there. The three discussed the boy's academic success, and the meeting ultimately ended with the decision of making the boy skip *another* year: from Year 5 straight to the first year of intermediate, Year 7. On the final day of Year 5, Narnia gave the boy one last present: a book with 101 facts about programming, computers, and numbers.

Surprisingly, the first day at intermediate was really nice for the boy. His new classmates, some who towered over him (and remember that the boy is already big for his age), welcomed him. The boy was 10 in 2019, and in a class full of 11 to 12 year olds, he came across as a cute little boy. The boy was very

unfamiliar with the warmth his fellow classmates share with him, and did not know how to reciprocate properly. He tried his hardest, but little did he know, he went off as annoying to his students in his class.

When he tries to be playful, he ends up hurting someone. If he tries to be helpful, all he does is get in the way. Even when he tried to be friendly, he made the other person uncomfortable. In the end, most of his classmates resented him. A classmate thought the boy was always eavesdropping on other people's conversations. To prove it, as he was conversing with someone, he called out the boy's name, who reflexively asked him if he needed anything. That was all the proof the classmate needed. The boy was unjustly labelled an eavesdropper, even though he was just reacting to the call of his name.

The students that did not outcast the boy, let him be. They allowed him to follow him around to a secluded area where they met up with other students in the school to play card games. The boy finally found a friend group he could hang out with, albeit they did find the boy annoying some of the time.

However, it was not enough. The boy wanted everyone to like him and so he often crossed the line when trying to impress his peers. One instance of this occurred in the school's science lab. While the teacher was doing a demonstration, the boy told the student beside him that he could throw his entire pencil case into a bin that was on the other side of his classroom. The boy attempted and missed horribly. The pencil case ended up next to the teacher's feet, and the teacher almost rolled her ankle stepping

on it. This incident was reported to the boy's head teacher, who contacted home.

Upon hearing this, the boy knew what was coming. He hid behind a rock at school and cried out of fear and dread. For the first time, all of the students in his class worried about him. They asked him what was wrong but he answered with silence. When the head teacher asked the boy what was wrong, finally, FINALLY, the boy told the truth. He told the head teacher what was waiting at home, and she contacted the appropriate staff to handle it. She left the boy alone by the rock as she took the rest of the class to a swimming lesson.

Soon, a man approached the boy. He introduced himself as Darren, and he handed the boy some tissues to wipe the snot off his face. He sat with the boy and asked him all sorts of questions, but he made sure to never

touch up on the subject of home. The boy started to become comfortable around Darren. He had to leave though, as school was almost over, and the boy was in complete fear once again.

By some chance, some universal stroke of luck, the man did not hurt the boy. He no longer cared about what the boy got up to at school. It was all the boy's business. The mother was a whole different story. Her tongue was sharper than ever before. All sorts of insults and derogatory terms rang upon the boy, who withstood the abuse for the time being.

Arguments between the mother and the father had started up again, and this time around, the fights would get so severe the two would not speak to one another for several days. The mother and the father would often sleep in different beds, and



sometimes the mother would not get out of bed for the entire day.

The next day at school, all the students avoided the boy. Even the ones that let the boy hang around them while they played cards mysteriously disappeared from their usual hang out spot. The boy would spend most of his solitude. School and home was no longer a yin and yang, but one was similar to the other, just less excruciating.

One afternoon, the boy was called into Darren's office. The two ladies from child protection services were there. This time, they cut straight to the chase. The two ladies asked if the boy wanted to talk about what was happening at home, and of course the boy remained silent. The ladies switched topics, and started talking about food with Darren, and soon the boy joined in. But when they

switched the topic back to the boy's home life, the boy clammed up again.

Sadly, the two ladies gave up trying to talk to the boy. They decided they had to resort to intimidation if they wanted what the boy is going through to stop.

Later in the day, the parents of the boy were extremely surprised to be met with a CPS worker and a policeman when they opened their front door. I do not know what words were traded between the adults, but I do know that it unfortunately had no effect on the behaviour of the mother and the father.

When the boy came home from school that day, the mother was enraged, screaming at the boy, asking him why he would ever call the police on his own mum. The man would remain silent, not talking to the boy. The silence would not last long though, as just

two weeks after, the man would hit the boy once again, a punch to the side of his head, this time for raising his voice at his little sisters.

The boy had enough. He ran out the front door of the house, sobbing uncontrollably. The man would eventually find the boy walking down a street, and stop by the curb to try and convince the boy to come back home. The man promised him he would never hit him again. The boy did not care and he continued to walk down the street. When the man gave chase, the boy ran into a nearby shop. The customers forced the boy's father out, and tried to think what the best next move was. Some wanted the police to be immediately contacted, some did not want the police to be involved, and some went off to intimidate the man. The mother also became involved, bringing her two daughters

with her to try and convince the boy to come home. The standoff between the customers and the parents lasted for 5 hours, and it went well into the night. Sadly, the boy decided to go back home, and it disappointed a lot of people, including me.

At home, the man and the boy sat down in the living room, and the man opened up to the boy. He told his son what his childhood was like, how he was a delinquent too when he was in his teens. The man never took his studies seriously, would smoke even at the age of 13, and would even get into fist fights with his teachers. The father's disobedience got so severely bad that the only way his father (the boy's grandfather) could think of fixing it, was to move to South Africa, and employ his son in the stonemason business. The man would spend long hours in tiring conditions, lifting rocks that weighed up to

100 kilograms. When the man grew older, he was recruited by an athletics academy, where he performed so well that his coach was surprised people like him could “run like that”.

The boy listened, but he still felt no emotions. His father was sharing a vulnerable story to him, but he had no interest. I applauded that, as I would have gone berserk. The father was clearly trying to justify the abuse the boy had gone through with his own upbringing that had shaped him to the man that he is today. Your wound does not pardon the weapon you choose later on. Causality traces the path of pain, but morality judges the choice to inflict it upon others.

Time passed, and the boy grew to 11 years old. In 2020, he was now a senior in his class. New students looked up to him and forced him to take on responsibility he was yet to be able to handle.

When the boy spoke of his hobbies in a group conversation, another student, an Indian boy, enquired about programming to the boy. Turns out, the Indian enjoyed playing video games, and would love to know how to make them. The boy would teach the basics of programming to the Indian and the two decided they should work on a game together. However, since the Indian taught himself how to develop games (just as the boy did), occasionally his ways of executing things were very different to the boy's preferred method. The boy would become mad at the Indian, telling him that if it was not how the boy would have done it, then it was wrong. It did not matter whether it achieved the same result, it just was not his way of doing things, and so it was wrong. The boy would come up with many excuses to try and control the Indian to do things the way

the boy would have done it: the written code is not clean, this would not work on other devices, it is not future-proofed, and so on.

In the end, the Indian grew frustrated and stopped working with the boy to make his own games. The boy would not realise it was all his own fault until many years later. He would also take an indefinite break from all programming.

2020 was also the year of COVID. For the boy, it meant spending the entire day at home. The father was on an indefinite leave from work and also spent all day at home. The tension between the mother and father would constantly grow, and soon daily arguments and fights would become a source of entertainment for the boy. The man would become increasingly distanced from the boy, while the mother became increasingly hurtful with her tongue. In

particular, the words “dumb”, “useless”, “retard”, “freeloader”, and “gluttonous” would become daily representations of the boy in the mother’s mind. Additionally, it was as if the lady could not stand the boy’s presence. If the boy was in the same room as her, she would leave; if the boy asked her for something, she would sigh deeply before answering. The time the mother would spend in bed all day would also slowly increase, even when she did not fight with her husband.

The boy’s relationship with his sisters also became strained. He found them annoying and would almost never play with them or talk to them. If they needed his help, he would reluctantly do so. There was no normal family talk; at the dining table they would eat their meals in silence, the family would never spend time together, and they only ever talked to one another if they absolutely had



to. The family was no longer a family, but just a bunch of people of different ages coincidentally living under the same roof.

It was expected that the boy became so bored during the lockdown that he would spend most of his time lying in his bed. It was by chance that one day he saw the book that Narnia had gifted him: the one with the 101 facts on programming, computers, and numbers. The boy started programming again, and this time, he enjoyed it like never before. He would spend his days clicking and typing away on the family computer, from day to night, making small video games until his eyes hurt and his fingers sore from typing. He wanted to make a video game and release it on the Play Store – that was his ultimate goal.

As the lockdown eventually lifted and the boy had started his first year of high school

(Year 9), the family would try to fix itself by going on trips and hikes around the country. All the efforts were in vain, as the family just could never seem to function properly. Something would always go wrong and ruin the trip; either the mother's mood will suddenly and drastically change, the youngest sister would start throwing a tantrum, the older sister annoying the mother, the father desperately trying to make his wife happy again when her mood changed but only made it worse, and the son not wanting to be outside the house at all. He just wanted to make his video games. These trips only put band-aids over lacerations in the family and the goal to become happy together again was never, and would never, be achieved.

The boy's video game was almost finished, and so he released a beta version of it, made

it playable on the browser, and shared the link to Internet strangers to play and get feedback from. It was a hell of a bad decision by the boy, as he would face intense backlash, with people telling him that he had copied other creators' work and there was not a shred of originality in the boy's game.

In truth, the boy did do exactly that. His creativity had long been dead and his problem-solving skills were next to zilch. The boy would not realise this for a long time and blamed the comments from the players of his game on the ruthlessness of the Internet. He still continued to make new games, but the passion was no longer there. He would boot up the game engine, but spend most of his time playing video games. In fact, after the failure of his first game, he would spend most of his time playing video games.

At school, he would ignore all the requests of other students to hang out with them, and would instead sit by himself in the library, playing games on his phone or on the library's computer, slowly developing a gaming addiction. I do not know how the failure of his game made the boy retreat into himself. Was it because he wanted to see what the popularity for his game could have been?

Due to the boy's self-isolation, he did not make many friends, but lots of students knew who he was. In a way, he was popular, but not the textbook definition of it. Many students found him interesting – after all, the boy was a 12 year old Year 9 who studies amongst normal 13 and 14 year old students. The boy's teachers would also find him fascinating. He would absorb information like a sponge and they only needed to repeat knowledge once for the boy to retain it. The boy's social studies

teacher asked him if he has an eidetic memory, to which the boy replied with no. I can confirm that is true.

However, the boy's mathematics teacher did identify an area of weakness for the boy. Quoted from the boy's Year 9 End of Year report: "Whilst he is extremely strong algebraically and computationally, he severely lacks in strength in statistical and contextual mathematics questions". Despite this, the boy would end up earning himself the title of top mathematics student in his year in 2021. He would gain a reputation for himself, but unfortunately that did not blossom into something further.

In Year 9, the boy also started playing football again. Unfortunately, after two years of not playing the sport, he was behind technically. The hard work of other players through the boy's inactive period had made it

such that his natural talent could no longer keep up. He was no longer the star-striker in his team, one could turn a bad pass into a goal, but instead he became someone that would desperately try and score every game. This made his teammates somewhat despise him, and he would be made fun of at school whenever he walked past the spot where all the students that were great at football hung out at.

At home, things were still degrading, but at a slower rate. The boy's parents would still occasionally behave as if they were going to divorce, and with each argument they would have, it would leave a mark on the boy's soul. He knew most of the arguments were about him; how he would always be playing video games, how he barely helped around the house, how he and his sisters barely talked anymore, and how the boy would barely talk

to the parents as well. Inside the boy, rage slowly built, as he grew frustrated and angry at the man and the lady. How could they not know all of the things they were arguing about were all because of them? Were they so blind to their own imperfections that they could only see others'?

He was old enough to understand things now – he had accumulated enough knowledge. The boy was no longer just a naive kid that did not know why the world was the way it is. He would start fighting back against his parents. When his mother screamed at him, he would talk back in a calm manner. If she hit him, he would stare her down. The boy slowly started making his disgust for the mother known; he would glare at her when she was not looking, pull faces at her behind her back, and would flip her off even when the man was watching.

The father, interestingly, barely cared about the boy anymore. He was now just another man the boy knew in the world. When the boy would talk to him, he very rarely responded. If the boy helped him out with chores such as moving heavy furniture, the man would not give out instructions verbally, and would expect the boy to know it telepathically. When the boy took his awards home from the Year 9 prizegiving, the father would not congratulate the boy, and later the boy would see the man had uploaded a social media post with his awards, with a caption of "First year at high school. Not bad". It was as if the man wanted the boy to never have approval from him. He would go so far as to say to the boy that he is studying hard for himself, not for the man, so why should he give approval? But that would raise the question, why was he so adamant on the boy



to stop gaming and study? He cared when the boy did not do what he wanted, but when he did, the man would not acknowledge it. The boy's mother did post about her son's academic achievements, but the son knew it was not because she was proud of him.

All these restrictions and no rewards made the boy rebellious. The father would make the boy keep his computer and phone outside in the living room at night and turn the WiFi off for the phone at 8PM to restrict the boy's screen time. However, the boy left an empty flip case in the living room and turned on Internet hotspot on the computer with the name being the same as the neighbour's WiFi, just so he could play mobile games late into the night. He would go to great lengths to fuel his addiction, such as figuring out how to keep the laptop's hotspot turned on when the lid was shut. The boy did not care at all

that he would go to sleep at 4 in the morning and had to wake up 3 hours later to get ready for school. He deemed the world that he lived not worth having his attention.

However, that would change very soon.

In Year 10, the boy's daily routine was more or less the same. Wake up, eat breakfast, go to school, play mobile games (in class if possible), return home, and play mobile games until very late into the night. He still lived a physical life of solitude and a digital life of opulence.

One day, in English class, one of the boy's classmates who sat behind him wanted to arm wrestle the boy. This specific classmate thought he would easily win, but little did he know about the boy's genetics, and so it came to no surprise that the boy would win easily. The classmate asked him how much he could bicep curl, and since the boy had never

stepped foot in a weight gym before, he estimated and said 10 kilograms. This hurt the classmate's pride even more, for he did not want to believe someone 2 years younger than him could bicep curl almost double what he did. Thus, a deal was made. If the boy could bicep curl 10 kilograms in front of the classmate, then he will ask out any girl the boy chose to a date. If the boy failed, he would face the same consequence.

The boy failed. He could not even complete one curl. And so, he was made to ask out a girl by the name of Mila the very next morning. The boy was not scared, such things no longer make him afraid, but it did consume him for the rest of the day and well into the night. He had never asked a girl out before. Mila was in 4 of the boy's classes: Science, English, Maths, and Physical Education. But due to the boy's self-induced

introversion, he had not spoken to Mila once before.

Before long, the morning had arrived. The boy walked to school and sat in his spot in the science lab. Students slowly filled up the classroom. The classmate from yesterday sat next to him, his eyes practically shooting lasers of glee at the boy. Other boys in the class had been filled in on what the boy was going to do this class. They all sat in suspense, waiting for Mila to walk into the classroom. No one made a sound, and the rest of class was weirdly creeped out. They would ask themselves how come the usual monkeys were once finally behaving like proper humans? When Mila finally walked into the class, they kicked themselves in the leg for thinking of such a question, as the room was suddenly full of jeers and cheers toward the boy. Seemed like there was really no escape.

So, when everyone was prepping lab equipment for that day's lesson, the boy walked up to Mila. He mumbled, "Would you like to go out with me?", and Mila replied "Would I or will I?", but the boy was already walking back to the other classmates and did not hear this. One of them had secretly filmed the entire exchange.

They laughed at the boy, telling him that he could have just said one of the other boys wanted to go out with her. None of them could believe it. Was this kid so innocent due to his young age that he would just blindly follow orders from a senior? The boy felt humiliated, but on the outside, he acted like their words did not hurt him. He laughed with them, whilst on the inside he wanted to run away and hide.

The boy and Mila would not speak at all for a few days, until one night, when the boy had

gotten tired of the current mobile game he was playing, he decided to friend Mila on social media. I have no idea what compelled him to do such an action at the time. Was he not humiliated the last time he had interaction with her? To the boy's surprise, Mila eventually accepted his request, and the two started talking. I do not know the full details as to what they initially talked about, but I do know that the boy did start to have feelings for her.

The two would slowly start to talk in class as well, and even when the seating arrangement meant they could not verbally talk, they would still talk online. In English class, it was routine for the boy to grab a class laptop and open Facebook Messenger so he could talk with Mila non-verbally. One student realised this routine was happening and looked wildly back and forth between Mila

and the boy, which caused the two to go bright red.

Mila was also the reason that the boy started becoming more active, and slowly got past his gaming addiction. The boy started playing competitive badminton for the first time just so he could spend more time with Mila after school. The two would often play 1v1 or doubles together and the boy would see his rapid progression in the sport. He became good enough that he could challenge the best players in the school and score points against them. The boy also started to spend less time playing video games in the library, and instead spent time with the football boys that continued to mock him to this day. He endured their insults that they said were “jokes”. Those who could not take them were labelled as “fun-sponge” or “buzzkill”. The boy would also start to behave like those football

boys, and for the rest of the time the boy was at this school, they were his main group of “friends”.

The boy realised he *really* liked Mila, and so one night, when the two were chatting, he made the ultimate decision. He decided to tell Mila his past. He talked about the abuse that he faced, the acts that he had to endure, the struggles that he had to go through. He told her that it was a combination of all of those events that had shaped him to what he is today. Mila listened to everything the boy said, and surprisingly, she shared some of her trauma too. It was not at a scale like it was for the boy – he would only meet one or two other people in his teenage life that went through similar things like he did, but it was still touching for the boy that someone would share their trauma to him.

It was what made the boy love Mila.



She was the first girl that the boy would truly love, and it was the only girl for a very long time. The boy himself would not realise it until 2 years later as he thought he long forgotten how to love someone. Mila never changed how she acted around the boy after that night, and it made the boy love her even more. For someone to not define others by their trauma (especially ones that were as deep and painful as the boy's), is a testament to their capacity to see the personhood beneath the scars, recognizing that a victim's history is a chapter of their life, but never the whole book.

Mila would start receiving gifts from the boy, mainly in origami form. Origami swans represented love and hope in Japanese culture, and the boy would give these to Mila, who kept all of them. More conspicuously, the boy would also give origami flowers to her.

Mila reciprocated these gifts by giving the boy an origami butterfly that she made. It was a treasure to the boy, as it was the first ever present a kid his age would give him. He would obsess over it, studying the butterfly so that he could reverse-engineer the folds.

However, all good things must come to an end. The boy never explicitly told anyone his true feelings for Mila, and for some unknown reason that I still have not discovered today, he felt ashamed that he liked her. He did not want to admit nor wanted anyone to suspect he loved Mila.